

SWIM & WATER SAFETY GLOSSARY

Swim & Water Safety Teaching Resource Suite | Glossary of Terms & Acronyms

A comprehensive reference of all terms, acronyms, organisations, and curriculum codes used across the full teaching resource suite. 126 terms across A–W. For teachers, students, and families.

About this Glossary

This glossary covers all terms, acronyms, organisations, and curriculum codes used across the Swim & Water Safety teaching resource suite — for Year 7–8 and Year 9–10. Entries are arranged alphabetically within grouped A–Z sections. Category colour coding is shown in the legend below.

Category legend:

■ Organisations	■ Curriculum	■ Medical / Physiology
■ Water Safety	■ Legal / Policy	■ General

#

1-10-1 Rule

Cold water survival framework
Water Safety

1 minute — control gasping reflex and breathing; 10 minutes — window of useful swimming before muscles fail; 1 hour — approximate time before hypothermia causes unconsciousness (varies with water temperature, clothing, body composition).

A

AAPPC Framework

Audience · Aim · Persuasion · Platform · Credibility
General

A structured framework for analysing or designing health communication campaigns. Used in the Cross-Curricular Literacy Unit to analyse real water safety campaigns (LSV, SLSS, RLSS UK).

Cross-Curricular Literacy Unit (Year 9–10)

ACARA

Australian Curriculum, Assessment and Reporting Authority
Curriculum

Federal body responsible for the Australian Curriculum. Victoria uses the Victorian Curriculum F–10 developed by VCAA, which is informed by but distinct from the national curriculum.

Source: acara.edu.au

Adjudication

Curriculum

The process of evaluating and reaching a verdict in a structured debate. A panel of adjudicators assesses each team under three criteria: Matter (quality of arguments and evidence), Manner (delivery and confidence), and Method (structure and rebuttal quality). The panel delivers specific feedback before announcing the winner.

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

AED

Automated External Defibrillator
Medical / Physiology

A portable device that analyses heart rhythm and delivers a shock if needed to restore normal heartbeat. Provides audio/visual instructions — safe for untrained bystanders. Found in many public locations including pools, beaches, and schools. Step D in DRS ABCD.

Source: stjohnvic.com.au

Affirmative (Debate)

Curriculum

The team in a structured debate that argues IN FAVOUR of the motion. The first affirmative speaker defines the motion, states the team's three arguments, and delivers the first argument with at least one cited statistic. Contrast with: Negative (Debate).

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

AIHW

Australian Institute of Health and Welfare
Organisations

The Australian Government's national agency for health and welfare statistics. Produces the definitive data on aquatic injury, spinal cord injury from diving, and other injury-related health outcomes in Australia. The AIHW Diving Injury Report is a primary source for the diving and spinal injury content in this suite.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Extension Workbook Q6.1

Airway (A)

DRS ABCD — Step A
Medical / Physiology

Third step in DRS ABCD. Tilt the head back gently to open the airway, preventing the tongue from blocking the throat. Allows breathing to commence or be assessed.

Alcohol (as a risk factor)**Water Safety**

Contributing factor in approximately 20–30% of adult Victorian drowning deaths. Impairs judgement, coordination, thermoregulation, and creates overconfidence near water. Linked to the higher male drowning rate and unpatrolled location deaths.

Source: lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/

Aquatic Spinal Injury**Medical / Physiology**

A spinal cord injury sustained in or around water, most commonly from diving or jumping into water shallower than anticipated. Unsafe diving accounts for approximately 10% of all spinal cord injuries and 20% of quadriplegia cases in Australia (AIHW). 95% of patients are male; 75%+ are under 30; two-thirds suffer permanent disability.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster

AREA Method

Acknowledge · Refute · Evidence
· Affirm

Curriculum

A four-step framework for constructing a spontaneous rebuttal. A = Acknowledge the opposing argument; R = Refute it with a specific reason; E = cite Evidence; A = Affirm how this strengthens your position. Used to respond to opposing arguments in real time.

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

AUSTSWIM

Australia's peak body for
swimming and water safety
instruction

Organisations

Australia's national peak body for swimming and water safety teaching. Provides qualifications and professional development for swim teachers and water safety instructors across all ages and abilities.

Source: austswim.com.au

B**BeachSafe**

SLSA beach conditions service
Organisations

Free online and app service (Surf Life Saving Australia) providing real-time beach safety: patrol times, hazard alerts, flags, rip current warnings, and marine stinger alerts for beaches across Australia.

Source: beachsafe.org.au

Breathing (B)

DRS ABCD — Step B
Medical / Physiology

Fifth step in DRS ABCD. After opening the airway, look, listen, and feel for breathing for up to 10 seconds. Look for chest rise, listen for breath sounds, feel for breath on your cheek. If not breathing normally, begin CPR immediately.

Bystander Effect**General**

Psychological phenomenon where individuals are less likely to help in an emergency when others are present, assuming someone else will act. Overcome by direct instruction to a named individual: "You — in the red shirt — call 000 now."

Year 9–10 Advanced Workbook, Quiz Question Bank

C**CALD**

Culturally and Linguistically
Diverse
General

Refers to people from backgrounds where languages other than English are spoken. CALD communities represent ~40% of Victorian drowning deaths despite ~28% of the population — a structural inequity driven by limited swim access, language barriers to safety messaging, and occupational risk (e.g. fishing).

Source: lsv.com.au/community/multicultural-safety/

Cardiac Arrest**Medical / Physiology**

When the heart stops pumping blood effectively. Can be caused by drowning, heart attack, or electric shock. Without CPR, brain cells begin dying after 4–6 minutes. Distinguished from a heart attack (blockage) — cardiac arrest is the electrical failure of the heart's pumping action.

Cardiac Output**Medical / Physiology**

Volume of blood the heart pumps per minute (~5 litres at rest). CPR compressions generate approximately 25–30% of normal cardiac output — sufficient to maintain minimum brain perfusion pending defibrillation or ROSC.

Year 9–10 Physiology section

Carnival (Swimming)**Water Safety**

An organised swimming competition or sports day held at a school or club. Victorian school swimming carnivals are governed by DE supervision ratios and safety protocols. Six cardinal safety rules apply: stay in lane, enter feet first, no running, no pushing, swim when directed, and stay visible at all times.

Swimming Carnival Student Briefing

CDC

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (USA)

Organisations

US federal public health agency. Publishes US drowning statistics and evidence-based prevention guidelines used for international comparison in the Year 9–10 unit. Most CDC content is in the public domain.

Source: cdc.gov/drowning/prevention

Cerebral Hypoxia**Medical / Physiology**

Oxygen deprivation to the brain — the terminal event in drowning. Brain cells begin dying irreversibly after 4–6 minutes without oxygenated blood. After 10 minutes without CPR, neurologically intact survival is extremely unlikely. The primary reason bystander CPR within 4 minutes is critical.

Cervical Spine*C-spine · C1–C7***Medical / Physiology**

The seven vertebrae (C1–C7) forming the neck portion of the spinal column. Houses the uppermost section of the spinal cord, controlling movement and sensation below the neck. A fracture or dislocation of the cervical vertebrae — the most common mechanism in diving-related spinal injury — can instantly cause permanent quadriplegia.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Extension Workbook Q6.2

Cold Water Shock**Medical / Physiology**

Physiological response triggered by sudden immersion in water below ~15°C. Causes an involuntary gasping reflex (aspiration risk), hyperventilation, and cardiac stress. Can incapacitate even strong swimmers within minutes. See: 1-10-1 Rule.

Year 9–10 physiology, inland waterway content

CPR*Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation***Medical / Physiology**

Emergency procedure combining chest compressions and rescue breaths. Adult ratio: 30:2. Rate: 100–120 bpm. Depth: 5–6cm. Allow full chest recoil. Continue until emergency services arrive or person shows signs of life.

Source: stjohnvic.com.au | heartfoundation.org.au

D**Danger (D)***DRS ABCD — Step D (first)***Water Safety**

Very first step in DRS ABCD. Before approaching, assess whether it is safe to do so. In water emergencies: check for rip currents, submerged obstacles, unstable banks. Never enter water to rescue unless trained — a panicking person can pull their rescuer under.

DE

Department of Education (Victoria)

Curriculum

Victorian state government department responsible for government schools. Publishes mandatory policies for swimming instruction, water safety education, and excursions. Sets minimum supervision ratios, consent requirements, and emergency procedures.

Source: www2.education.vic.gov.au/pal/swimming-instruction-and-water-safety-education/policy

Defibrillation (D)*DRS ABCD — Step D (last)***Medical / Physiology**

Final step in DRS ABCD. Use an AED if available — delivers a controlled electric shock to restore heart rhythm. Only shocks if heart is in a shockable rhythm; safe for untrained bystanders. Attach as soon as possible — do not stop CPR while setting up.

Distress Signal**Water Safety**

The internationally recognised signal for a person in danger in the water: raising ONE arm straight up and holding it there. A single raised arm — held still — is correct. Waving both arms can be misread. Lifeguards are trained to recognise this signal and respond immediately. LSV SwimSafe Rule 5.

Swimming Carnival Student Briefing; Student Workbooks Year 7–8; Diverse Learners Visual Guide

Diving-Related Spinal Injury

Medical / Physiology

A spinal cord injury resulting from striking the bottom, a submerged object, or a sandbank after entering water head-first. The force of impact compresses or dislocates the cervical vertebrae, which can sever or compress the spinal cord instantly. Highest incidence in children aged 10–14 (AIHW). Swimming ability is irrelevant once a head-first entry is underway.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster; Scaffolded Workbook Section 6

Drowning Rate

Deaths per 100,000 population

Water Safety

Standardised measure of drowning deaths accounting for population size. Formula: deaths ÷ (population ÷ 100,000). Victoria 2023–24: 0.78 per 100,000 (54 deaths, 6.9M population). Australian national average: ~1.2 per 100,000.

DRS ABCD

Danger · Response · Send · Airway · Breathing · CPR · Defibrillation

Medical / Physiology

Australian standard emergency action plan. D—check for danger; R—tap and call name; S—call 000; A—tilt head back; B—look/listen/feel for breathing; C—30:2 CPR until help arrives; D—use AED if available. Each step builds on the previous.

Source: stjohndvic.com.au

E

EAL/D

English as an Additional Language or Dialect Curriculum

Students who speak a language or dialect other than Standard Australian English as their first language. EAL/D students may require scaffolding, visual supports, and accessible materials. The simplified workbooks in this suite specifically address EAL/D needs.

Evidence Hierarchy

General

Ranking of research quality from strongest to weakest: systematic reviews → randomised controlled trials → cohort studies → case reports → expert opinion → anecdote. Used in Year 9–10 to evaluate the strength of drowning prevention strategies.

F

False Confidence

Water Safety

The psychological phenomenon in which prior positive experience at a location creates an unjustified belief that the same location is currently safe. Particularly dangerous near water because depth, visibility, currents, and submerged hazards change constantly — especially in inland waterways. The Bawley Beach case (NSW 2024) documents a sandbank forming between visits. Considered a structural prevention challenge, not merely an individual attitude problem.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster; Extension Workbook Q6.3

Fatal vs Non-Fatal Drowning

Water Safety

Fatal drowning results in death. Non-fatal drowning (survived submersion) represents the much larger burden — Victorian non-fatal drownings in 2023–24 were 60% above the 10-year average. Non-fatal events can still cause brain damage and secondary drowning.

Feet First, First Time

Water Safety

The core Australian prevention message for unknown water: always enter feet-first before diving or jumping at any unfamiliar location. Depth must be checked every time — not just on the first visit — as conditions change continuously. Applies to beaches, rivers, dams, lakes, jetties, and all non-pool environments. Promoted by RLSSA and Life Saving Victoria.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster; Diverse Learners Visual Guide

Float to Live

RLSS UK campaign — primary survival message

Water Safety

RLSS UK campaign teaching floating as the PRIMARY response to water emergency — particularly cold water immersion. Floating conserves energy, prevents panic, and allows the body to overcome cold water shock before attempting to swim.

Source: rlss.org.uk/float-to-live

Four-Sided Pool Isolation Fencing

Water Safety

Pool fence surrounding all four sides, completely separating pool from house. Strongest evidence-based intervention for child home pool drowning prevention — reduces risk by ~83%. Victorian legislation mandates four-sided fencing for new installations.

G

Gasping Reflex
Medical / Physiology

Involuntary sharp intake of breath triggered by sudden cold water contact. One of the most dangerous effects of cold water shock — if submerged at the moment of gasp, water is inhaled directly into lungs. Cannot be suppressed by willpower; prevention requires slow, controlled water entry.

H

Health Inequity
General

Health differences between population groups that are unfair, avoidable, and rooted in unjust social conditions. Distinguished from health inequality (any difference). The CALD over-representation in Victorian drowning deaths is a health inequity — caused by structural barriers that are avoidable with targeted intervention.

HPE
Health and Physical Education
Curriculum

Victorian Curriculum learning area covering personal health, mental health, physical activity, and movement skills. Swimming and water safety is mandated within HPE as a Safety (S) and Lifelong Physical Activity (LPA) focus area.

Hypothermia
Medical / Physiology

Dangerously low body core temperature (below 35°C). In cold water immersion, typically develops after ~30–60 minutes (third phase of the 1-10-1 Rule). Symptoms: severe shivering, confusion, loss of muscle control, unconsciousness. Seek immediate medical help.

Hypoxia
Medical / Physiology

Deficiency of oxygen reaching body tissues. In drowning, develops when water or laryngospasm prevents oxygen reaching the lungs. Leads to loss of consciousness, cardiac arrest, and ultimately cerebral hypoxia if not reversed. See also: Cerebral Hypoxia, Laryngospasm.

I

Inland Waterway
Water Safety

Any body of water located away from the coast — rivers, creeks, dams, lakes, irrigation channels, quarry swimming holes, and floodways. Royal Life Saving Australia identifies inland waterways as the highest-risk aquatic environment in Australia, with more drowning deaths than any other location. Key hazards: rapidly changing depth, poor visibility, cold water shock, no lifeguard supervision, remote access delaying emergency response, and group alcohol-related risk-taking.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster; Diverse Learners Visual Guide

Intersectionality
General

A person's experience of health and risk is shaped by the overlap and interaction of multiple social identities — gender, cultural background, socioeconomic status, age, disability. Example: a young CALD male may face compounded drowning risk from masculinity norms, limited swim access, and language barriers simultaneously.

Year 9–10 Social Determinants section

L

Laryngospasm
Medical / Physiology

Involuntary closure of the vocal cords triggered by water contact. In 10–15% of drowning deaths, laryngospasm persists and water never enters the lungs — "dry drowning." The person still asphyxiates due to inability to breathe. CPR is equally critical whether drowning is wet or dry.

Lifeguard / Lifesaver
Water Safety

Qualified water safety professional supervising swimmers. Lifeguards are paid professionals; lifesavers are volunteers. In 2023–24, zero Victorian drowning deaths occurred at locations with lifeguard supervision — all 54 deaths were at unpatrolled locations.

LPA

Lifelong Physical Activity (HPE focus area)
Curriculum

One of the focus areas in Victorian Curriculum HPE. Swimming and water safety is included within LPA as an activity students can engage in across their lifespan.

LSV

Life Saving Victoria
Organisations

Peak water safety body for Victoria. Publishes the annual Victorian Drowning Report, manages lifeguard services, operates the SwimSafe education program, and provides the Classroom Toolkit for school teachers. Primary data source for Victorian drowning statistics throughout this suite.

Source: lsv.com.au | lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/

M**Masculinity Norms**

General

Social and cultural expectations about how males should behave — including risk-taking and not backing down from dares. In 2023–24, males accounted for 85% of Victorian drowning deaths. Effective prevention strategies often reframe water safety as intelligence rather than weakness.

Year 9–10 Social Determinants section

Matter / Manner / Method

Curriculum

The three criteria used by adjudicators in a structured debate. Matter: quality, accuracy, and relevance of arguments and evidence. Manner: confidence, clarity, and persuasiveness of delivery. Method: logical structure of arguments, use of the speaking role, and quality of rebuttal. Students should consider all three criteria from the outset of preparation.

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

Motion (Debate)

"This house believes that..."
Curriculum

The proposition being debated, phrased as "This house believes that [statement]." The affirmative team argues in favour; the negative argues against. Effective motions are genuinely contestable — real evidence exists on both sides. This suite includes 12 water safety motions across Year 7–8 and Year 9–10.

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

N**Negative (Debate)**

Curriculum

The team in a structured debate that argues AGAINST the motion. The first negative speaker accepts or challenges the definition, rebuts the first affirmative argument directly, and introduces the negative team's three arguments. See also: Affirmative (Debate), Motion (Debate).

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

Non-Fatal Drowning

Previously: near-drowning
Water Safety

A submersion incident that does not result in death. Victorian non-fatal drownings in 2023–24 were 60% above the 10-year average. Can still cause brain damage and secondary drowning. See also: Secondary Drowning.

O**Over-Representation**

General

When a group accounts for a larger share of an outcome than their population share. If CALD communities are 28% of population but 40% of drowning deaths, their over-representation ratio is $40 \div 28 = 1.43$. A ratio of 1.0 = proportional representation. Indicates structural inequity.

P**Paddle Australia**

Organisations

National body for paddling sports in Australia (kayaking, canoeing, rafting). Provides waterway safety guidelines, river grading systems, and safety standards for recreational paddling. Referenced in inland waterway and excursion risk management resources.

Source: paddle.org.au

Patrolled Location**Water Safety**

Aquatic venue with qualified lifeguard supervision. Marked at beaches by red and yellow flags. In 2023–24, zero drowning deaths at patrolled locations in Victoria. See also: Unpatrolled Location.

PFD*Personal Flotation Device***Water Safety**

Buoyancy aid worn to keep the wearer afloat. Different levels (50, 100, 150) provide varying buoyancy for different activities. Required to be worn at all times during school kayaking/paddling excursions per DE policy.

Post-COVID Drowning Trends**Water Safety**

The documented increase in drowning deaths among young Australians (aged 15–20) following the COVID-19 pandemic. RLSSA research found drowning among 15–20 year olds increased by 34% in the five years after COVID-19 compared with the five years prior. Associated with changed recreational patterns, reduced access to supervised aquatic facilities during lockdowns, and increased informal use of unpatrolled waterways.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster

Primary Source**General**

Original data, research, or official publications — not secondary summaries. In this suite: LSV Victorian Drowning Reports, WHO Drowning Fact Sheet, RLSSA National Data, St John guidelines, Victorian Curriculum documents. Students are expected to cite primary sources with full URLs.

Pulmonary Oedema

Fluid in the lungs — see: Secondary Drowning

Medical / Physiology

Accumulation of fluid in the lungs. In water safety, can develop hours after a non-fatal drowning event (secondary drowning). Symptoms: coughing, fatigue, chest pain, laboured breathing. Rare but potentially fatal.

Source: stjohndvic.com.au

Q**Quadriplegia***Also: Tetraplegia***Medical / Physiology**

Paralysis of all four limbs (both arms and both legs), typically from injury or disease affecting the cervical spinal cord. In water safety, the most catastrophic outcome of a diving-related spinal injury — caused by cervical vertebrae fracturing or dislocating on impact. Unsafe diving accounts for approximately 20% of quadriplegia cases in Australia (AIHW). Two-thirds of aquatic spinal injury patients suffer permanent disability.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Extension Workbook Q6.2; Myths vs Facts Poster

R**Rebuttal****Curriculum**

A spoken response to an opposing argument in a structured debate. An effective rebuttal uses the AREA method: Acknowledge the opposing argument accurately, Refute it with a specific reason, cite Evidence, and Affirm how this strengthens your own position. Rebuttal speakers should not introduce new arguments — they identify the key clash point and argue why their team wins it.

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

Red and Yellow Flags*Always swim between these flags***Water Safety**

The international beach flag signal marking the safe swimming zone under lifeguard supervision. The most important beach safety rule — always swim between the flags.

Reframing*Persuasion technique***General**

A persuasion technique that repositions an idea within a different frame of reference rather than opposing the audience's values. Example: instead of 'don't take risks,' reframing says 'real strength is knowing when not to jump in.' Used in the Cross-Curricular Literacy Unit.

Remote Rescue Delay**Water Safety**

The extended time taken for emergency services to reach victims at inland waterway locations, due to distance from urban centres, limited road access, poor mobile phone reception, and absence of lifeguards. RLSSA identifies remote rescue delay as one of five key factors making inland waterways Australia's highest-risk aquatic environment. Delay worsens neurological outcomes following both drowning and spinal cord injury.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6

Response (R)*DRS ABCD — Step R***Medical / Physiology**

Second step in DRS ABCD. Tap shoulders firmly and call name loudly. No response = unresponsive — proceed immediately to S (Send for help). Do not move a potentially injured person unless they are in immediate danger.

Rip Current**Water Safety**

Narrow, fast-moving channel of water flowing away from shore, up to 2.5 m/s. Escape: Stay calm · Float · Swim parallel to shore (not against the current) · Angle back to shore once clear of the rip · Raise one arm to signal for help.

RLSS UK

Royal Life Saving Society UK
Organisations

UK's national water safety charity. Developed the 'Float to Live' campaign. Referenced in Year 9–10 resources for international comparison of prevention approaches.

Source: rlss.org.uk/education

RLSSA

Royal Life Saving Society
Australia
Organisations

Australia's peak drowning prevention organisation. Publishes the National Drowning Report, operates the Swim and Survive program, and provides the RLSSA Water Safety Framework. Primary source for national drowning statistics.

Source: royallifesaving.com.au

ROSC

Return of Spontaneous
Circulation

Medical / Physiology

When the heart restarts pumping on its own after cardiac arrest — the goal of CPR and defibrillation. Even after ROSC, medical assessment is essential as the person remains at risk of re-arrest.

S**Safety (S)**

HPE Focus Area — Victorian
Curriculum
Curriculum

One of the focus areas in Victorian Curriculum F–10 HPE. Swimming and water safety is mandated within the Safety focus area across Year 7–10.

Sandbank**Water Safety**

A raised area of sand beneath the surface, formed by tidal action, river flow, storm surge, or sediment deposition. Sandbanks can form, shift, and disappear within hours or days, dramatically and unpredictably altering water depth. Frequently invisible from above the surface. The Bawley Beach jetty incident (NSW 2024) and Torquay Front Beach incident (Vic 2025) both involved sandbanks reducing depth at previously safe jumping locations.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster

Secondary Drowning

Delayed pulmonary oedema
Medical / Physiology

Pulmonary oedema developing hours after a non-fatal drowning event. Symptoms may appear up to 24 hours post-incident: coughing, laboured breathing, fatigue, chest pain. Rare but potentially fatal. Always seek medical review after any submersion — even if the person appears fine.

Sediment**Water Safety**

Particles of sand, silt, gravel, clay, or organic matter that settle on the bed of a river, dam, lake, or coastal waterway. Sediment accumulation progressively reduces water depth over time and creates hidden shallow zones at previously deeper locations. One reason prior knowledge of a location's depth cannot be assumed to remain accurate between visits.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6

Send for Help (S)

DRS ABCD — Step S · Call 000

Medical / Physiology

Third step in DRS ABCD. Call 000 immediately — or direct a specific person: "You — call 000 now." State your exact location, describe what has happened, whether the person is breathing. Stay on the line.

SLSASurf Life Saving Australia
Organisations

Australia's peak coastal water safety body. Coordinates the volunteer lifesaver patrol network, manages BeachSafe, and advocates for beach and coastal safety. Surf Life Saving Victoria (SLSV) is the Victorian arm.

Source: sls.com.au | beachsafe.org.au**SMART**Specific · Measurable ·
Achievable · Relevant ·
Time-bound
General

Framework for writing effective goals and success metrics. Used in the Community Action Project Guide for designing evaluation criteria.

Social Determinants of HealthWHO framework
General

"The conditions in which people are born, grow, live, work, and age" (WHO). Includes income, education, cultural background, access to services. In water safety: explains why CALD communities, males, and low-income households face disproportionate drowning risk.

Source: who.int**Socratic Seminar****Curriculum**

A structured discussion method where students in an inner circle respond to a central question, building on and challenging each other's reasoning while an outer circle observes. The teacher poses the initial question but does not direct the discussion. Used in this suite as an alternative to full structured debate.

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

Spinal Cord Injury

SCI

Medical / Physiology

Damage to the spinal cord resulting in partial or complete loss of motor function, sensation, or autonomic function below the level of injury. Classified by level (cervical, thoracic, lumbar, sacral) and completeness. Unsafe diving accounts for approximately 10% of all spinal cord injuries in Australia (AIHW) and is a leading cause of cervical-level injury in young males.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Extension Workbook Q6.1

Spinal Immobilisation**Medical / Physiology**

The emergency first aid procedure of keeping the spine — particularly the cervical spine — stable and aligned to prevent further damage to a potentially injured spinal cord. In remote waterway locations, delayed paramedic access for spinal immobilisation is a key factor worsening outcomes in suspected diving-related spinal injuries.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6

St John AmbulanceSt John Ambulance Australia /
Victoria
Organisations

Australia's leading provider of first aid training. Provides the DRS ABCD guidelines used throughout this suite. Victorian arm (SJA Vic) operates at public events and provides first aid training to schools.

Source: stjohnvic.com.au**Structural Factors****General**

System-level causes of health outcomes outside individual control — government policy, infrastructure, access to services, social norms. Contrasted with individual-level explanations. Effective public health intervention must address structural factors, not only individual behaviour.

Submersion**Water Safety**

Being underwater — specifically the airway being below the water surface. The first stage in the physiological sequence of drowning. Distinguished from immersion (body in water but airway above surface).

SwimSafe 5 RulesLSV water safety framework
Water Safety

1. Read signs — check flags and warnings; 2. Enter feet first — never dive into unknown water; 3. Stay in depth — only swim where you can touch the bottom; 4. Swim with a friend — never swim alone; 5. Signal for help — raise ONE arm if you need assistance.

Source: lsv.com.au

T

Throw, Don't Go*RLSSA rescue principle***Water Safety**

Never enter water to help a drowning person unless specifically trained in water rescue. A panicking drowning person can pull an untrained rescuer under. Instead: throw a rope, ring, pool noodle, towel, or any floatable object. Call 000 first.

Source: royallifesaving.com.au

Tidal Depth Variation**Water Safety**

The change in water depth at a given location caused by the rise and fall of tides. Tidal variation can reduce depth at a jetty, wharf, beach channel, or rock platform by several metres between high and low tide. A location safe to jump into at high tide may be dangerously shallow at low tide. Contributing factor in the Terrigal Wharf incident (NSW 2025).

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Myths vs Facts Poster

U

Unpatrolled Location**Water Safety**

Any aquatic venue without lifeguard supervision — unpatrolled beaches, rivers, dams, lakes, creeks, home pools. In 2023–24, all 54 Victorian drowning deaths occurred at unpatrolled locations.

V

Vasoconstriction (Peripheral)**Medical / Physiology**

Narrowing of blood vessels near the skin in response to cold, redirecting blood to vital organs. In cold water immersion, contributes to muscle failure (part of the 10-minute swimming window) by limiting blood flow to limbs.

VCAA

Victorian Curriculum and Assessment Authority
Curriculum

Victorian government body developing the Victorian Curriculum F–10, VCE, and VCAL. Publishes all official content descriptions and achievement standards. All resources in this suite are aligned to VCAA-published documents.

Source: victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au

VCAL

Victorian Certificate of Applied Learning
Curriculum

Senior secondary certificate for applied/hands-on learning including vocational study. Community action project and cross-curricular literacy resources in this suite connect well to VCAL pathways.

VCE

Victorian Certificate of Education
Curriculum

Victoria's senior secondary certificate (Years 11–12). Health and Human Development VCE subject has strong connections to Year 9–10 water safety content — particularly social determinants and community health promotion.

VCELY

Victorian Curriculum English — Language Year-level codes
Curriculum

Content description codes for Victorian Curriculum English. Used in the Cross-Curricular Literacy Unit connecting HPE water safety to English curriculum outcomes — text analysis, persuasive writing, and media literacy.

VCHPEM codes

Victorian Curriculum HPE — Movement & Physical Activity
Curriculum

Content description codes for the Movement and Physical Activity strand. VCHPEM146 — Year 7–8 aquatic movement contexts; VCHPEM162 — Year 9–10 specialised aquatic movement concepts (survival swimming, rescue techniques).

Source: victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au

VCHPEP codes

Victorian Curriculum HPE —
Personal, Social & Community
Health
Curriculum

Content description codes for the Personal, Social and Community Health strand. Year 7–8: VCHPEP125 (health decisions), VCHPEP126 (health information), VCHPEP129 (strategies for health), VCHPEP130 (safety). Year 9–10: VCHPEP143 (health behaviours), VCHPEP144 (evaluate using data), VCHPEP147 (community capacity), VCHPEP148 (evaluate health information).

Source: victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au

Vertebrae

Singular: Vertebra
Medical / Physiology

The 33 interlocking bones forming the spinal column, protecting the spinal cord and supporting the body's structure. Five regions: cervical (neck, 7 bones), thoracic (mid-back, 12), lumbar (lower back, 5), sacral (5 fused), coccygeal (4 fused). In diving-related spinal injury, the cervical vertebrae are most vulnerable — fracture or dislocation at C4–C6 commonly results in permanent quadriplegia.

Year 9–10 Workbook Section 6; Extension Workbook Q6.2

W**Water Watcher**

Water Safety

Designated adult whose SOLE responsibility during aquatic activities is continuously scanning the water for distress. Must not be assigned any other tasks while on duty. Rotate every 15–20 minutes. Required role in the Excursion Risk Management Template.

WCAG 2.2

Web Content Accessibility
Guidelines version 2.2
Legal / Policy

International standard for web accessibility (W3C). Specifies contrast ratios, keyboard navigation, focus visibility, language attributes, and landmark elements. All HTML resources in this suite have been reviewed and updated for WCAG 2.2 compliance.

Source: [w3.org/TR/WCAG22/](https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/)

WHO

World Health Organization
Organisations

International public health agency of the United Nations. Publishes global drowning statistics (~320,000 deaths annually; 90% in low/middle-income countries), the Social Determinants of Health framework, and evidence-based drowning prevention guidelines.

Source: who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/drowning